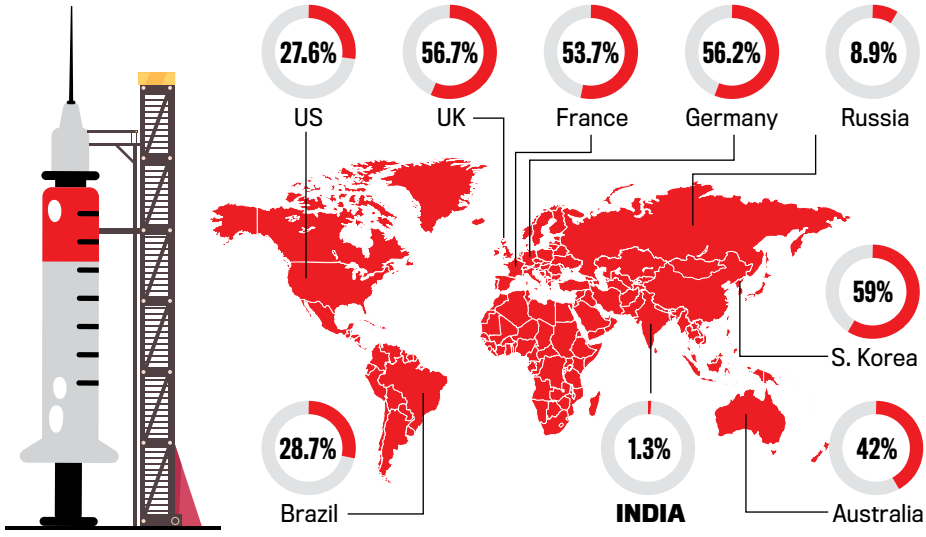
THE BOOSTER ROSTER

In the Omicron wave, vaccination with a booster reduced chances of hospitalisation and death by over 90 per cent. Most countries now are racing to give their people a third dose. Given below is the percentage of people who have got the booster. India still has a long way to go



"Living with the virus does not mean there won't be seasonal surges," says public health expert Dr Gagandeep Kang. "To prevent deaths and severe disease during these waves, vaccinations and surveillance of new strains are crucial." The unvaccinated also allow the virus to mutate further, running the risk of breeding a strain that trumps currently available vaccines.

India has vaccinated a majority of its adult population. According to government figures, more than 76 million children between the ages of 15 and 17 have also been inoculated. The next key challenge is booster shots for all. Vaccination with a booster dose reduced hospitalisation and death by more than 90 per cent, according to NHS during the Omicron wave in the UK. "Antibody counts start to reduce after a certain amount of time," says infectious disease expert Dr Ankita Baidya. "Some studies have shown that despite low antibodies, immune cell memory has helped keep the symptoms mild even if it hasn't prevented infection. A booster will help improve Covid immunity certainly against variants with advanced immune escape mutations."

The good news is that India has a lot more approved vaccines this year compared to 2021 when public vaccinations had begun. In December 2021, India approved Serum Institute of India's Covovax. It was followed by approval for the ZyCoV-D vaccine—the world's first DNA vaccine against Covid. Cipla has been authorised to import the Moderna vaccine even as Johnson & Johnson's single-dose vaccine and Sputnik Light, a component of the Russian-made Sputnik V vaccine, have been approved. "The country's vaccination programme has come a long way," says Dr Guleria. "We have many more options for acquisition today than we did a year ago and have gained invaluable experience in logistical and administrative preparations for large-scale inoculations."

Among the vaccines to get emergency use approval in India is Corbevax, a protein subunit vaccine developed by the Hyderabad-based pharma firm Biological E. India's third homegrown vaccine, it has been approved for use in those between 12 and 18 years of age. "Protein subunit vaccines are safe and have less side-effects than other kinds of vaccines," says Dr N.K. Arora, chairman of the National Technical Advisory Group on Immunisation (NTAGI)'s Covid-19 working group. "These vaccines also have higher antibody levels and are easy to store." The government has placed an order with Biological E for 50 million doses of Corbevax, each costing Rs 145. Another order for 300 million doses had been placed in August 2021. Two more promising vaccines are in the pipeline—HGCO19, India's first mRNA vaccine made by the Pune-based Genova in collaboration with the Seattle-based HDT Biotech Corporation; and a nasal vaccine by Bharat Biotech.

"To administer boosters to over 900 million adults, we need a ready supply but also more options for vaccines, particularly those showing higher efficacy," says Dr Kang. Despite 10 approved vaccines, only Covishield, Covaxin and Sputnik V are available currently in the national vaccination programme for adults, with Covishield accounting for around 85 per cent of the doses.

According to sources in the Union ministry for health and family welfare, the decision to open up booster doses for all adults is still pending. With over 15 countries having started booster doses, and some like Germany and the UK having given it to over 50 per cent of their people already, the case for booster shots grows stronger by the day. The faster India follows suit, the greater the chances of the next wave also being mild.

While Covid itself is here to stay, Omicron's short duration and mild temperament inspires hope that the pandemic could end this year. How soon it will happen will depend on the global vaccines administered. Ending the pandemic is no longer in the hands of one country but of the entire world. ■